

By Nirmala Ravindran

There was never a doubt that the i-pill and other emergency contraceptive pills (ECPs) would prove to be immensely popular among women in India when they were introduced two years ago. That's because India records 11 million abortions annually and a shocking 20,000 women die because of abortion-related complications. What better way then to have a pill that promises 95 per cent success if a woman takes it within 12 hours of having unprotected sex? Known as morning after pills—though a woman can take them even immediately after sexual intercourse—their efficacy to prevent pregnancy drops to around 58 per cent if taken between 12 hours and 72 hours. After that period, the manufacturers of these pills are explicit that it will not be able to prevent pregnancy. They are also clear that these pills are an emergency contraceptive and, more importantly, not a substitute for regular contraception that provides comprehensive protection against an unwanted pregnancy.

Unfortunately, in India some of these messages don't seem to have gone out loud and clear, causing rising concern among some citizen groups about such emergency contraceptive pills being made freely available over-the-counter (OTC). The controversy has taken on a moral shade with some activists objecting to the advertisements showing young girls as the end-users with a not so subtle implication that they had unprotected sex. Like N. Selvaraju, director, drug control, Tamil Nadu, says, "We are not against women's rights, but this is a moral concern. The advertising of this drug will mean that women will think, 'I can do anything and there is an easy way not to get pregnant'. We can't allow such an attitude to grow." The state drug control directorate even sent a notice to a popular Tamil magazine for publishing advertisements of the i-pill. There are several such moral groups in India that want to ban advertisements promoting the ECP and also its over-the-counter sale. Women's right groups in Chennai along with the Tamil Nadu

Government's Directorate of Drug Control claim that the i-pill advertisement violates the Drug and Magical Remedies Act of 1954. That saw the i-pill being prevented from being sold in Tamil Nadu despite being cleared by the Drug Controller General of India (DCGI).

On the other hand, the medial community and some women's rights groups have welcomed the ECP as a weapon of women empowerment. "Young girls didn't start having sex after the ECP was introduced as statistics of the high rate of abortions in the past indicate. Thanks to the ECP, there are ways to prevent unwanted pregnancies among a sexually active section of the

society. It is a boon for a rape victim," says Rajashree Gawde, who works with Stree, a women's rights group in Pune. Gawde hopes ECP like the i-pill will continue to be available over-the-counter rather than as prescription drugs. "Going to a doctor to get a prescription means loss of precious time during an emergency and negates the very purpose of the ECP," she reasons. The mounting pressure from panicking parents of young girls, some activists, state governments and the Advertising Council of India resulted in a review being undertaken by the DCGI. Much to the relief of the proponents of the ECP, the DCGI, however, decided against



Problem **PILL**